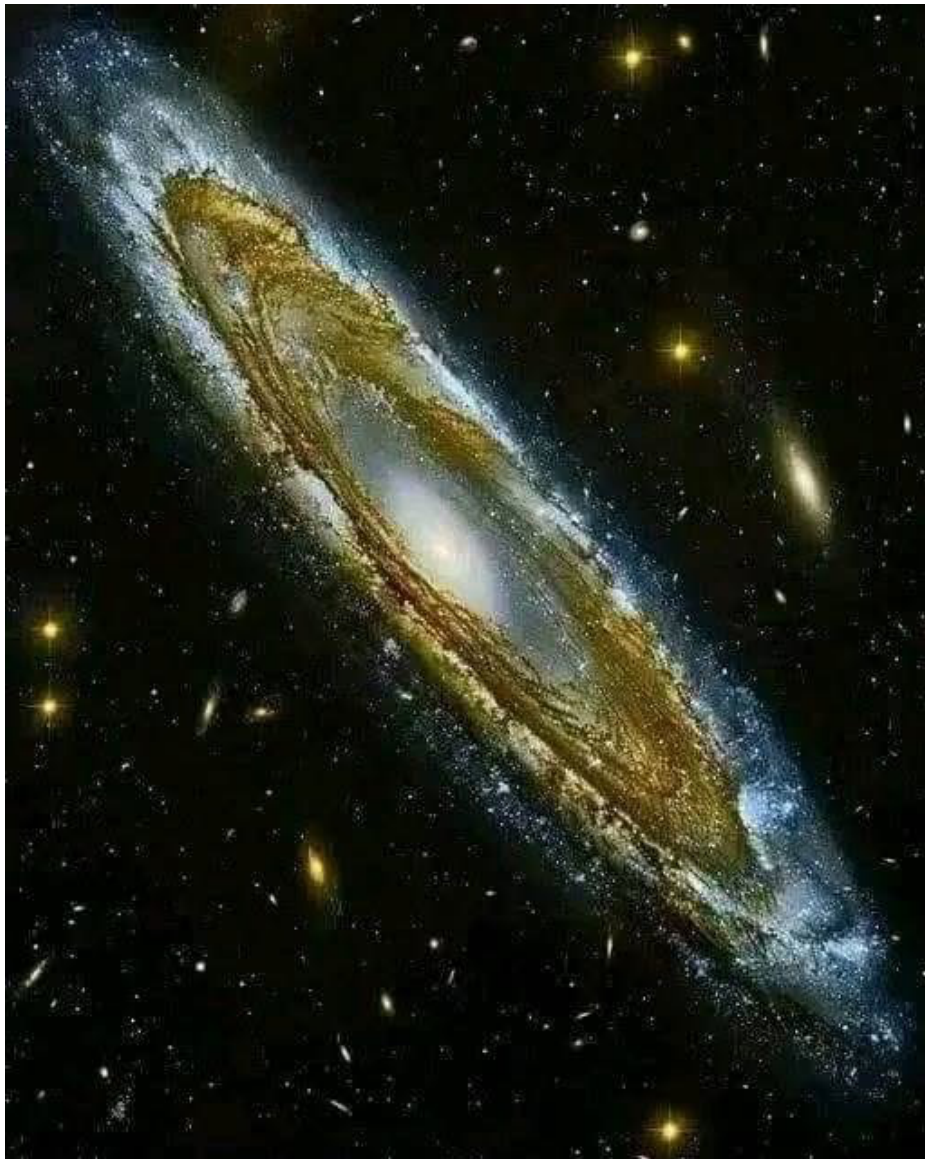


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 4

Painting the Stars ~ An Anticipatory Universe

27 September 2026



*Andromeda Galaxy
NASA James Webb Space Telescope*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert
TBD

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Sarah Fuhrmeister

In the beginning was a sound, a silence,
a consonant, a vowel,
a mumble, a sigh,
a shout.

In the beginning was an idea,
a possibility, an urge and an urgency,
a compulsion, a wonder,
a love.

In the beginning was the Word,
the Creation, the Articulation,
the Invitation, the Choice,
the Name, the Yes.

This morning as we worship the God of all language and nuance,
we pray that our hearts will break open to the new beginnings
that surround us in this sacred space. [rhackenberg]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee

ODE TO JOY

Joyful, joyful, we adore you, God of glory, God of love;
Hearts unfold like flowers before you, opening to the sun above.
Melt the clouds of sin and sadness, drive the storms of doubt away;
Giver of immortal gladness, fill us with the light of day.

All your works with joy surround you, earth and heaven reflect your rays,
Stars and angels sing around you, center of unbroken praise.
Field and forest, vale and mountain, flowery meadow, flashing sea,
Chanting bird and flowing fountain teach us what our praise should be.

You are giving and forgiving, ever blessing, ever blessed,
Well-spring of the joy of living, ocean depth of happy rest!
Loving Spirit, Father, Mother, all who love belong to you;
Teach us how to love each other, by that love our joy renew.

Mortals, join the mighty chorus, which the morning stars began;
God's own love is reigning o'er us, joining people hand in hand
Ever singing, march we onward, Victors in the midst of strife;
Joyful music leads us sunward In the triumph song of life.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

God of Creativity,
whose renewing breath fills our planet,
may we discover your vibrant, creative presence among us.
On this day, may our spirits be lifted as we celebrate
with the clouds, the winds, the dusk, and the dawn.

And then, O God, as we stand in awe
before the vast reaches of space above us,
may we give thanks for this fragile piece of stardust
we call Earth.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

Grand Celebration
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

DEREK HAYES

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Dear One, closer to us than our own hearts, farther from us than the most distant star,
you are beyond naming. May your powerful presence become obvious not only in the
undeniable glory of the sky, but also in the seemingly base and common processes of the earth.
Give us what we need, day by day, to keep body and soul together, because clever as you have
made us, we still owe our existence to you.

*We recognize that to be reconciled with you, we must live peaceably and justly with other
human beings, putting hate and bitterness behind us. We are torn between our faith in your
goodness and our awareness of the evil in your creation, so deliver us from the temptation to
despair. Yours alone is the universe and all its majesty and beauty.*

Good caring presence within us, around us, and above us; Hold us in a sense of mystery and
wonder. Let the fullness of your goodness be within us and around us; Let all the world know
your ways of caring and generosity.

*May we find we have all we need to meet each day without undue anxiety. Overlook our many
stupidities, and help us to release everyone from their stupidities. May we all know that we are
accepted.*

Strengthen us so that we will reach out to the best, always with the faith to rise above the ugly realities of our existence. And as we celebrate the gifts you have given us – the rich kingdom of life's possibilities, the power to do good and the triumphs of good, let us be ever thankful for the moments when we have seen the glory and wonder of everything!

*You are life's richness. You are life's power. You are life's ultimate meaning.
Amen and Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

The peace of the morning's stillness
the peace of new beginnings
the peace of heaven's kiss
to welcome us to this day
to root us in this day
to free us for this day
that we may grow with the greening earth
that we may grow from the ground of glory
that we may grow in grateful wonder of You
Gracious Giver of this day
Great Giver of this day. [jphilipnewell]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition from Genesis 1

Sarah Fuhrmeister

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.
Before that there was only empty darkness and the deep
eternal waters.
But in the dark, a wind began to stir.
It was the breath of life.
It was God saying, 'Let there be light.'
And there was light.
God saw that it was good.
There was a time for light and a time for darkness.
The light was called day and the darkness night.
And there was evening and morning, creation's first day.

This is the witness of the ancients...
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People
Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Silence

Rev. Lehman

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious God, how often our names for you
fail to describe your majesty and mystery.
When we think we have captured your essence,
another realm appears,
reminding us you are beyond
all language and image.
You speckle the ink-dark night with your star-writing,
you soften the sun-stark day with your cloud brush.

Our minds can barely comprehend –
the ways in which you continue to work
with the single-celled to the infinitely-complex creatures,
as you continually create and re-create.

You speak slyly from inside the bosons
and stride boldly beyond the galaxies.

You cannot, must not, will not be contained
by our meager words and skewed vision,
yet you answer our cries, no matter the name we use.

*Teach us, Eternal One,
to work beyond the bounds of our labels and language.
Help us to leave the comfort of our narrow images.
Remind us that you are All in All,
and that no matter who we are,
or where we reside,
you are with us
in all space and time.
Amen and Amen!*

[Jerry Hebenstreit / adaptlvf]

Meditation Anthem

Lux Aurumque
Laude, Katelyn Dietz, Solo, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Conductor

ERIC WHITACRE

Sermon

An Anticipatory Universe

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Prayer of Blessing

Holy One,
we come to this table,
incarnating in our blood and bones,
in chemistry and consciousness,

this shape-shifting universe.

As we receive this bread and this cup –
symbols of self-giving love,
we remember Jesus and his love that continues
to evolve in each of our lives.

We pray this with the Spirit of Life
that flowed through Jesus
and now flows through our bodies
and into this world.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Sarah Fuhrmeister

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Choose Something Like a Star

RANDALL THOMPSON

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Eternal God, we pray aware that you,
who are at work
in the vastness of this universe
for billions of years,
will now come to visible
and audible expression
in and through these offerings.

With appreciation in our hearts,
we rejoice, O God,
that you breathe life and vitality
into our world,
into our lives,
and into our gathering here,

connecting us on the deepest level
with all that exists.

*For this and so much more,
we offer our thanks on this day.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

May the Great Mystery that we call God
keep alive in each one of us
the search for a Faith that is real;
a Faith that helps us to lead genuine lives;
a Faith that gives us a fuller
meaning to life and the events of life.

*Bring us to know the goodness that flows
from the heart of the universe,
and may we be expanded in heart and soul
by that goodness.*

*This is our prayer...
May it be so for all of us!*

Choral Response

We are the Ones
We are the ones we've been waiting for

BERNICE JOHNSON REAGON

***Hymn for the Journey**

When in Awe of God's Creation

HYFRYDOL

When, in awe of God's creation, we view earth from outer space,
This mysterious, floating marble, strewn with clouds and bathed in grace,
How can we not pause in wonder, seeing earth as one and whole?
As we heal our proud divisions, may earth's healing be our goal.

Blue and tan, with lace clouds swirling, flung in space and circling there,
Habitat for myriad creatures meant for land and sea and air!
Must we draw our lines of hatred marking nation, class, and race?
God, forgive us, we entreat you, for all pride of self and place.

Living now, this is the picture we no longer can deny,
For we see no angry boundaries when our view is from the sky:
Rivers, deserts, forests, snowfields, oceans, lakes, and mountains too,
But no fences built for barring you from me or me from you.

Postlude

TBD

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Inside The Music

“In today’s exploration of the theme *An Anticipatory Universe* we “ring in the new” with Grace leading our Cathedral Ringers. Bells traditionally signifying a call to something new...an anticipation of announcement or time or an invitation to guide our spirits, as they do today in the Derek Hayes *Grand Celebration*.

In meditation, we center the philosophy by 6th century Celtic monk, Pelagius, who taught that human nature at birth is already a reflection of the Divine—that God exists in all creatures, human and non, and that when we look into the face of a newborn baby, we look into the face of God. Whitacre’s anthem *Lux Aurumque* sets the short poem by Edward Esch, “*light, warm and heavy as pure gold, and the angels sing softly to the newborn babe.*” While typically sung at Christmas time, today we sing these words in our meditating on the theme of a universe that anticipates—that there in the face of a newborn is God—a hope and anticipation that exists within each of us, and that enlightens our interactions with one another. This gentle and tender, majestic and magical, careful though excited treatment of one another is heard throughout the piece in close harmonies, anticipatory homophonic rhythmic language, and the spectrum of dynamic color.

In the Offertory Anthem, Randall Thompson’s setting of the Robert Frost poem *Choose Something like a Star*, Thompson has composed music that is all the way throughout anticipatory in nature. With a bass line that gives consistent heart beat, with scalar passages leading us from one place to the next, with harmonic language that keeps us listening and engaged as it constantly leads us somewhere else, and with a dynamic scope that landscapes and illustrates the range of human emotion, we can hear Frost’s poem as he marvels at the Universe. And at the close of our day, we sing Bernice Johnson Reagon’s setting of a call from the Civil Rights movement—*We are the ones we’ve been waiting for*. In the face of a newborn baby reflecting the Divine, in rung celebration of something new, in the stars whose brightness burns within us, we must be the ones to dream love, change, justice, equity, light into our world.” ~ Dr. Ianthe Marini